

Driverless vehicles: Will it be a commercial reality in 2016

Google is the first name that comes to mind when we talk about driverless automotive technology. Now we have Apple and even automobile companies like Toyota making investments into the research and development of driverless cars. While all major multinational organisations are looking at automating passenger cars for public roads, an Indian based Silicon Valley start-up, Auro Robotics, is focusing on a niche category of last-mile public



Auro Prime detects pedestrians and alters its route accordingly

transportation by building driverless shuttles for in-campus travel. This gives them the advantage of not waiting for regulations to fall in place for driverless automobiles as their target is contained, like private environments such as universities with big campuses, closed grounds, gated colonies, airports and tourist places. For instance, it would allow college students to take these shuttles to attend classes at different locations on a campus and also go to other places within the campus. Auro Robotics will be carrying out trials of their autonomous shuttles at California's Santa Clara University (SCU) campus this fall.



An inside view

The electric vehicle, Auro Prime, uses an assortment of sensors like GPSes, cameras, radar and laser scanners to create a 360° view under all environment conditions. Like Google's car, Auro Prime too relies on a 3D map of the environment, which is usually created in the beginning. The 3D map helps the automobile to localise itself and understand road topography. Passengers can input their destination either through a touchscreen interface or an application on their mobile phone.

Auro Prime is programmed to steer clear of pedestrians by altering its route or also halts completely if the situation demands. Their current prototype also measures speed and direction of the pedestrian to assess if those pedestrians will still be in the path, giving more lead time to adjust the route and speed.

The prototype at SCU is Auro Robotics' only vehicle. Depending on the feedback from testing, future cars could occupy up to five passengers or more, which would be apt for amusement parks, resorts, zoos, golf courts and others. Auro Prime will be available in the USA and European market from 2016 onwards.

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